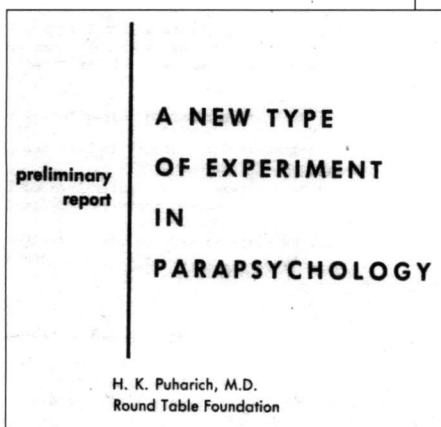




Memorandum

THE PROPOSITION

Henry K. Puharich, M.D., of the Round Table Foundation Laboratory of Experimental Electrobiolgy, Glen Cove, Maine makes the following claim:

that through the agency of an electrophysical technique developed by him it is now possible to potentiate the claimed "super-sensory perception" of a sensitive individual so that he can demonstrate in practical tests an ability to gain intelligence about a person, event, or thing in the complete absence of any presently known mode of human or instrumental communication.

Examples:

- 1) Subject A can give a facsimile picture of handwriting performed by another individual at a distance of many miles.
Accuracy: About 80% in terms of content in about 50% of trials.
- 2) Subject B can give a fairly accurate character portrayal of the writer of a letter simply by handling a letter which is sealed in an opaque envelope.
Accuracy: About 80% correct in about 60% of trials.
- 3) Subject C can answer any questions asked of a person who is not present under the following conditions:
 - (a) the questioner must personally have known the individual of whom information is asked.
 - (b) the questioner must give the name of the individual who is to be interrogated.
 Under these conditions Subject C can name a relevant person in the situation, and portray the mental and emotional reactions as implicit in the mind of the particular person in that context.



STRANGE DAYS, PART 2

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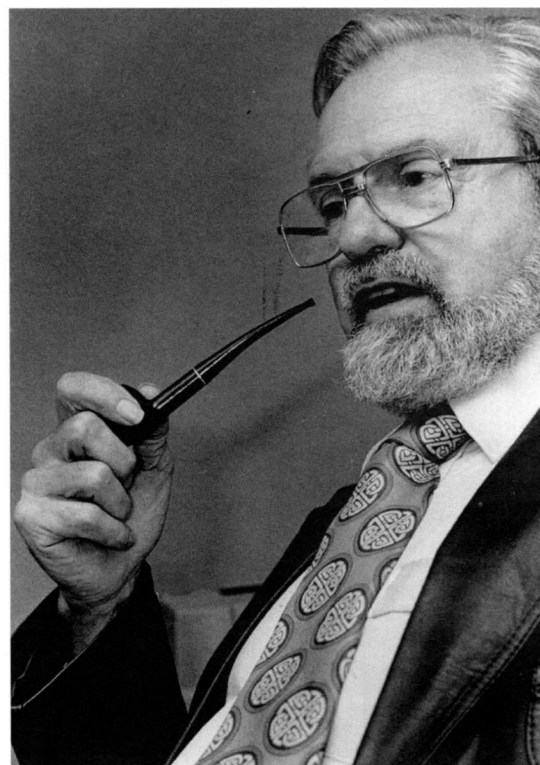
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CHALLENGES AND ADVANTAGES IN RESEARCHING ANOMALIES

BY HENRY H. BAUER

If you get interested in something like UFOs—in my case it was Loch Ness monsters—it's natural to think that you're doing what science does, what scientists do: trying to understand some aspect of the natural world. But you're not. Being aware of the differences can help to avoid some of the frustrations and annoyances that come with this territory.

The biggest difference is that we're amateurs, whereas scientists are professionals. That means we have some advantages, but I'm going to talk first about the disadvantages.

Scientists nowadays enjoy a tremendous supporting infrastructure that we don't. We rarely get financial support and we rarely have secretaries or assistants or backup. We can rarely communicate our findings in mainstream publications, so we rarely reach all the people who might be interested. We don't have the benefit of peer review; and no matter how infuriating, incompetent, or unfair peer review can be—and I've had my share of those—it does help safeguard against committing blunders.

Our subjects typically touch on several fields of knowledge. Nobody can possibly be competent in all of them, so advice from specialists would be invaluable; but the mainstream experts usually brush us off, often unkindly, and so we make more mistakes than we might otherwise. Any mistakes we make are seized on by the defenders of the orthodoxy, and we are in a vicious circle. Our research demands getting into diverse fields, it makes some mistakes inevitable, and those are then held against us by those who refused to help us avoid the mistakes in the first place.

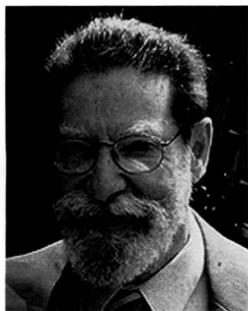
We're aware of the advantages that scientists have through their organized associations and societies, and so we establish our own. But there's a great difference between

associations of professionals and associations of amateurs. The professional associations bring a certain social standing and recognition, and spokespeople for them usually get a certain amount of respect from the media and therefore the public; our associations don't. Scientific societies bind and discipline their members with both carrots and sticks. The carrots are awards, prestigious positions, career-promoting credentials, opportunities to meet people who can help with jobs and grants; and side benefits like cheaper insurance premiums, including professional liability insurance. The sticks include the opposite of some of those things. Careers can be and have been damaged when professionals step out of line in behavior and when they question too directly or fundamentally the prevailing intellectual paradigm.

By contrast, our associations have little or nothing in the way of carrots and sticks. The main carrot is our mutual interest in the subject. But that interest doesn't reside within an established paradigm, as the interests of mainstream scientists do. So we find a great range of differing viewpoints among those who have supposedly the same interest as we do, and it's typically the case that we split into separate and more or less competing (and even sometimes antagonistic) groups. That further discredits us in the eyes of the mainstream.

I think such schisms are essentially unavoidable and systemic, but they play out through the actions of individuals; for example, the best association we had for cryptozoologists, with a couple of decades of meetings and a very respectable journal, just disappeared because of the willfulness of a single individual. You can fill in for yourselves the analogous situations in ufology, which I know only vaguely; but one of the main themes at the last meeting of the Society for Scientific Exploration was ufology, and I could observe at first hand the disparate, conflicting views of people like, say, John Alexander, James Carrion, Jerry Clark, Paul Hellyer, Claude Swanson, and Robert Wood. And I'm aware of the divisions over things like contactees, hypnotic recovery of memories, the extraterrestrial hypothesis, and Roswell.

In purely intellectual terms, too, we can't do what science does. Basically, science ignores anomalies, things that don't fit in, until such time as they *can* be fitted in or, rarely, they get so troublesome that they bring about the sort of revolution described by Thomas Kuhn in *The Structure of Scientific Revolutions* (1962). By utter contrast, we're



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interested precisely in the things that *don't* fit in. One trouble is that those things are very unlikely to be reproducible on demand—that's one of the reasons why science shoves them aside and can't do anything with them. No one knows how to get more information about Loch Ness monsters. A few people have spent most of their lives with binoculars, cameras, boats, sonar, fish-bait, cages, every conceivable method that might work, and so far nothing has. Scientists are professionals, they have to get results, and looking for Nessies just isn't likely to bring results in any foreseeable timeframe.

Around 1980, Peter Sturrock realized that people like ourselves need a scientific-type of society and publication. So astronomers and physicists interested in UFOs joined with parapsychologists and cryptozoologists and founded the Society for Scientific Exploration to provide a forum for these subjects that would be as disciplined and rigorous intellectually as mainstream science, and that would publish a journal equally as rigorous and disciplined as any scientific periodical. I was lucky enough to be in on the founding of that society. I've gained enormously from it, I was the first book review editor of the *Journal of Scientific Exploration*, and for seven years I was editor-in-chief. That brought home to me the perhaps quintessential, inescapable difference between science and what we call "anomalistics." We're dealing with subjects about which not enough is known to sustain truly objective peer review. (Not that peer review ever is truly objective, but the failings are usually owing to the people who do it, not to the lack of sufficient background understanding). It's so much harder for us than it is in established fields to distinguish between hypotheses that are unlikely yet possible on the one hand, and so unlikely as to be not worth publishing on the other hand.

There is no good basis for really *understanding* the phenomena we're interested in. Scientists don't have that disadvantage. Even cosmologists can envisage scenarios potentially capable of explaining their phenomena—in part, of course, because they're happy to think that equations that work constitute a satisfactory explanation even when they're quite absurd, like an infinite number of universes increasing in number all the time, or string theories that bring in some ridiculous number of so-called dimensions. The main thing is, their phenomena and the speculative theories cohere in some way.

That's not the case with our subjects. We have no really good explanation, an explanation so good that all the main evidence fits into it so well that all, or at least most, of the other people interested in the matter agree with our explanation. The best fit with eyewitness accounts and photos and films of Loch Ness monsters are creatures that died out 60 million years ago, the plesiosaurs; but if there are plesiosaurs in Loch Ness, they ought to be seen much more often because they breathed air. There isn't anything in known

non-air-breathing creatures that ever looked even remotely like Nessies or was anything like that big. There just isn't a good explanation, or at least no one has come up with one. But there's a film that unquestionably shows a very large creature moving very fast in Loch Ness in 1960.

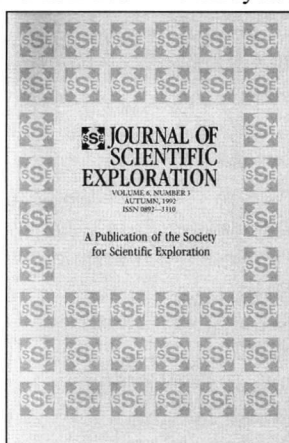
One of the sorest differences between science and what we do is the way we have to rely a great deal on eyewitnesses. Bob Rines likes to remark that people have been hanged on less evidence than there is for Nessies; he's a lawyer, and courts of law have established ways of testing and accepting eyewitness evidence. But we're often trying to get *science* to accept eyewitness testimonies, and the criteria in science are much more rigorous than in the law.

It's also true that we can be fooled by the evidence of our own eyes. In periods of a few weeks at a time, in total I've spent a year or two at and around Loch Ness, a good part of the time actually looking at the water, because we rented a holiday cottage overlooking Urquhart Bay. I've seen many things that can simulate a Nessie sighting, and once I even filmed one. Through good binoculars, I've identified quite a few phenomena that the unaided eye could easily believe to be a Nessie. I've never actually seen one for sure. Nevertheless, I trust some the people who have: Tim Dinsdale, who had three sightings besides the one he filmed, Bob Rines, and some others.

Still, I can't be quite sure *what* they saw, because I once saw a UFO that wasn't. Four of us were having dinner outside a restaurant in Lexington, Kentucky, in the early evening, with gray skies but plenty of light. A round object approached at some height, with lights flashing on and off underneath it. All four of us were excited enough to leave the meal. Telling the waiter we'd be back to finish it, we rushed to the car and followed the UFO for as long as we could, but it soon disappeared. So we went back to our meal. And the thing came back! But this time its path was exactly overhead, and we could see that the lights spelled out "Goodyear." It was a Friday, there was a football game coming up the next day, and the blimp had already arrived. So there were four reasonable people, all of whom agreed originally on its being a UFO; if it had not come back straight overhead, that's what we would have believed to this day.

So anyone can be wrong, groups of people can be wrong, and yet some of the best and most reliable evidence we have stems from eyewitness reports. Years later, at Loch Ness, my wife and I watched a shiny object quite far away in the sky, that just got smaller and smaller and then disappeared. My guess is that it was an earth satellite, but that's obviously just a guess.

Anyway, we not only have organizational problems and intellectual problems that mainstream science doesn't, we also have people problems that science doesn't. There are some individuals who claim to be interested in Loch Ness monsters just as I am, but who are more willing to go really



far out with explanations—people who think Nessies are psychic phenomena or who connect them with UFOs, say. In mainstream fields, there's usually no problem judging who really is a kook and who isn't, and in keeping out the kooks—though of course they sometimes make mistakes and exclude the wrong people or let in the wrong people. But on the whole, their judgments suit their purpose, and it doesn't damage their enterprise in the short run and usually not even in the long run. But we can't really judge who is likely to contribute usefully to our work and who isn't. Anyway, we don't have a mechanism for keeping them out even if we could identify them.

We had quite a few discussions about this in the Society for Scientific Exploration over the years. On the one hand, we tried to emphasize scientific-type rigor and discipline by having a high and traditional barrier for full membership: Ph.D. or equivalent, tenured academic position or equivalent, and mainstream publications. (Some of us would laugh in private as we described some of the really kooky people who have all those qualifications.) But the trouble—and we keep talking about it in SSE—is that some of the most important work in the fields we're interested in is done by people who don't have those credentials. We compromised by making the programs of our meetings more open than the peer-reviewed journal; and as a result, many of us consciously grit our teeth and bite our tongues at some the presentations that this open-door policy brings in. But there's no certain way to draw a dividing line, no criteria available for judging accurately what's potentially sound and what's never going to be.

I like to quote my friend Jack Good, a truly eminent and widely respected statistician and philosopher: "Cranks are geniuses who happen to be wrong, and geniuses are cranks who happen to be right." Einstein too once remarked that there's no way of telling which is which, except by later hindsight, sometimes *much* later.

A great disadvantage we have that scientists don't is that some people feel perfectly free to say things about us that stop just this side of the legal definitions of libel or slander, and sometimes go over that limit. I suggest that the best antidote to that is to be aware of the advantages we have over scientists.

As to name-calling, it can't hurt us the way it can hurt professional scientists. When a scientist's work is trashed, that threatens his livelihood and career; it doesn't threaten us in that way, because we're amateurs. I've often said over the years that because in academe I practiced chemistry and history of science, and had some administrative stints, I was free to pursue Nessies and similar subjects as a hobby; but if I had been a biologist, interest in Nessie would have been a career-stopper—it has been for at least one American and one British biologist that I know of. Milton Friedman is credited with the observation that academic freedom is enjoyed most by tenured full professors approaching retirement; but it's enjoyed even more by fully retired professors—and by amateurs.

I used to argue with ignorant criticisms by reviewers of my professional work in chemistry and in science studies, because it was important to me to overcome their objections in order to get published.

But nowadays I find I'm able to ignore that sort of thing and put it out of my mind. Not long ago, I got two reviewers' comments that had obviously been solicited with the sole purpose of rejecting my manuscript; one was one sentence long, the other was a couple of pages of character assassination using guilt by association. I didn't even finish reading it, as it was so obviously not worth the time and the journal not worth pursuing.

When we're wrong about something, it's no skin off our livelihood. When the fanatical defenders of orthodoxy, like the science groupies in such so-called "skeptics" groups as the Committee for Skeptical Inquiry (formerly CSICOP), call us names and denigrate our evidence, we can bear in mind that those people are to be pitied. Their fanaticism reveals a tremendous need to feel utterly secure in their beliefs.

A friend who is a member of SSE but who also attends a skeptics group regularly did a survey to test one of his observations: that many of these fanatical nay-sayers had been brought up in overly strict religious households and had rebelled against them. The survey amply confirmed his hypothesis. People raised to be unquestioning believers don't become moderate, questioning thinkers if they lose that belief. They have to find another belief to be unquestioning about, in this case whatever it is that science happens to say at a given time. They typically don't realize that science is usually right—when it's right at all—only in the short run, as the history of science tells us. To these pseudoskeptics, as Marcello Truzzi called them, it's a psychological catastrophe to be wrong about something. Yet even a moment's thought should be enough to recognize that human beings are wrong about all sorts of things all the time. Of course, it hurts my pride if I find I've been mistaken about something I believed, but if someone tries to make me feel worthless because of that I can respond, "What? How awful! I was wrong—unlike you and all the other people who are never wrong."

"Amateur" is often used in a disparaging sense, but I'm using it in the original and primary meaning—someone who does a thing for the love of it, not as a hired hand. It's not so long ago that the Olympic games were restricted to amateurs. In my favorite sport, cricket, it was within my living memory that British international teams were always captained by an amateur, a "gentleman," not a professional, a "player."

Doing something for the love of it is actually how modern science began. Up to the 17th century, there weren't any professional scientists, people making a career from doing research. The word "scientist" was first coined in the early 19th century, and it was toward the end of that century before one could earn a living doing research as well as teaching. For many decades, professional scientists could still keep their practices fairly close to the amateur ideal, choosing

(continued on page 18)

LETTER

MORE ON THE HILL CASE

To the editor:

I was so pleased to read Greg Sandow's article about the Indian Head encounters conference ("The Hill Case and the Limits of Ufology," *IUR* 31, no. 4, pp. 3–7, 19–28). He mentioned numerous questions that remain unanswered due to insufficient information, along with the inclusion of a great deal of conjecture, especially on the part of the skeptics and debunkers. As usual, they offered many speculative statements based upon scant evidence, which seems to reveal an emotional investment in debunking the Hill case.

I was not invited to remain at the conference for the discussions but I do possess the answers to most of the questions posed that remained unanswered. They are in my book *Captured! The Betty and Barney Hill UFO Experience*, coauthored with Stanton T. Friedman and published by Career Press/New Page Books in 2007. As the trustee of Betty's estate, I have all of her files, archival letters, personality tests, hypnosis tapes, medical reports, etc. Although I had believed in the literal reality of the Hills' abduction during much of my life, I became highly skeptical about it nearly 20 years ago. Because its impact upon me had been so life-altering, I decided to devote years to a research project to separate fact from fiction and fantasy from reality. I was not emotionally invested in proving the literal reality of the abduction, only in searching for the truth. My work served as the foundation for *Captured!*

I was surprised to learn that the participants were uninformed about the forensic analyses on Betty's dress. My book includes a chapter on the several chemical analyses performed over a 25-year period. Leonard Stringfield was the first to submit swaths of her dress to the chemistry department at the University of Cincinnati in 1978. Analytical chemist Phyllis Budinger, a world-class research scientist who worked for BP/Amoco (formerly Standard Oil of Indiana), for 35 years conducted the most impressive analysis over a three-year period. Her conclusion? Her analyses support the abduction event. Additionally, Pinelandia Biophysical Laboratory did seed-germination experiments on Betty's dress with some interesting results.

In *Captured!* Stan discusses Marjorie Fish's star map investigation and his involvement in it and takes on the debunkers in a chapter titled "Disbelievers and Disinformants."

Greg mentioned that there was much speculation about Barney's visits to my grandparents' farm in Kingston, New Hampshire. (I resided across the street from them.) I think that Barney walked around my grandparent's 35-acre (not 335) family farm to ponder his many questions about the period of missing time, to attempt to jog his memory, and to allow nature to ease some the stress he was experiencing. I don't think that he was clinically depressed, but it is clear that he felt stressed. It was after one of these walks that he entered

my childhood home and experienced a classic abreaction as he described the nonhuman gait and appearance of the men he encountered at the capture site. This occurred prior to his hypnosis sessions with Benjamin Simon.

I concur with Greg's observation that people who tell the same stories many times settle into certain ways of telling them. But I think that Betty's retelling of the event changed over time due to boredom. Late in her life, she informed me that, in her opinion, no amount of evidence would convince the debunkers that her abduction was real. She had grown tired of meticulously restating the event after years of having done so. I think that she became less careful about her statements and added humor to amuse herself and her listeners. Humor was a very important part of Betty's life, particularly during her long battle with cancer.

Finally, I wish to offer a few corrections. My name is Kathleen Marden, not Marsden. To be more accurate, I was a 13-year-old adolescent in 1961 when I observed the shiny circular spots on the trunk of Betty's vehicle, not exactly a child. I had not repeated that information over and over again, as Greg speculated that I might have done, because I had distanced myself from ufology during my professional career as a social worker and educator. But by the mid-1990s I had been appointed to the International MUFON Board of Directors as the director of field investigator training, a position I held for more than 10 years. In 2001, my first article about my observation was published in the *MUFON UFO Journal*.

In closing, I want to thank you for publishing Greg's excellent article. I had been curious about the conference proceedings for many years and he answered many of my questions. I only wish that his article had been included in *Encounters at Indian Head*. It would have added balance to a generally skeptical book.

Kathleen Marden
Coauthor of *Captured!*



UFOCAPTURE V2 SOFTWARE

SonotaCo is run by a Japanese researcher who has perfected a system to digitally capture and analyze transient aerial phenomena. Version 2.22 of its UFOCapture time-shifted motion capture software was released November 28. It requires Windows Vista/XP/2000, a Pentium 2.4 GHz chip or faster, and a DirectX video capture device (such as a USB camera or a PCI tuner/video capture board). The cost is 18,900 Japanese yen, which is roughly \$204, but it also has a 30-day trial version, as well as a completely free version (with limitations). The UFOAnalyzer v2 software calculates a moving object's coordinates, angular velocity, direction, linearity, and magnitude. For more information and download instructions, see sonotaco.com/e_index.html.



STRANGE DAYS, PART 2

BY MICHAEL D. SWORDS

A few issues ago (*IUR* 30, no. 4), I wrote an article about George Hunt Williamson, George Adamski, and whether the United States intelligence community might have been meddling with them. In the issue immediately preceding that one, Nick Redfern had written an article about more recent surveillance related to UFOs in Britain, and I had no reason to connect the two (and still don't). But then I bought a copy of *The Anomalist*, no. 12, and there was Redfern again, this time writing largely about the era of the "Strange Days," the 1950s. He said many interesting things in that article, some of which rang a few bells in this dusty old cranium, so I'd like to share with you an interleaving of his insights with what I can add to the story.

First, let me summarize a portion of Redfern's article in *The Anomalist*. Soon after World War II, the U.S. intelligence community suspected the Soviets were involved with flying-saucer fringe groups. Before 1950, the FBI began hearing stories about people who claimed to be in contact with space intelligences. The contactees were receiving these messages mentally, much in the same way as spirit mediums channeled disembodied entities. Some of the content seemed politically dangerous, such as discourses on peace, universal brotherhood, anticapitalism, and the social imbalances that the Western economic system produced. It all seemed much too sympathetic to communism.

When Adamski surfaced, his speeches, café chatter, and trance ramblings were right in line with all this, and in 1950 someone ratted him out to the FBI. Because UFOs were allegedly involved (and the Air Force had been working with the FBI on this since July 1947), both the FBI and the Air Force Office of Scientific Intelligence at the Pentagon began keeping tabs on "the Professor." By the time Adamski claimed his famous meeting with a Venusian near Desert Center, California, in November 1952 (seen from a distance by Williamson and others), the FBI-OSI file on Adamski must have been fairly thick. Official interest extended to other trance-channeling, UFO-brother-preaching contactees, like Williamson, as soon as their supposed un-American tendencies were noticed.

Michael D. Swords is professor emeritus of the Environmental Institute, Western Michigan University, Kalamazoo.

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COSMIC SCIENCE

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the Promotion of Cosmic
Principles and Truths
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QUESTIONS AND ANSWERS

Series No. 1

Part No. 1

Quest. #18. Do they use money as a means of exchange on other planets?

Ans. No. Their means of exchange is a commodity and service exchange system, without the use of money. All production is for the benefit of everyone, with each receiving according to his needs. And since no medium of exchange such as money is involved, there are no "rich"; there are no "poor". But all share equally, working for the common good. This may well be called a system of production for use.

Excerpt from an Adamski pamphlet from 1958 that contains answers from the Space Brothers, who apparently get along quite well without capitalism.

Anyway, the FBI and OSI quizzed Adamski shortly thereafter; Redfern says the FBI and OSI were at Adamski's home in January 1953. Even in the paranoid McCarthy era, this seems a little too much interest in a guy who is pretty obviously an engaging but crankish nut. But Redfern supplies a reason: By the end of 1952, operatives in the intelligence community were taking seriously a rumor that the Soviets had found a way to enhance telepathic communications and were capable of manipulating useful dupes by sending them messages and desirable (from the Soviet perspective) thoughts aimed at influencing their behavior.

This supposedly crystallized for the agencies after certain ESP lectures held at the Pentagon in November 1952 by one Henry Puharich. That's when the bells went off for

me. The reason for my “light bulb” moment is that I own a copy of Puharich’s report, *A New Type of Experiment in Parapsychology*, so I know it is real and that it fits perfectly into the story. So, what is this part of the tale all about?

Andrija (Henry) K. Puharich (1918–1995) was an American citizen with a medical degree from Northwestern University who, after his residency, became interested in



Andrija Puharich in the 1950s

parapsychology. He made his living with medicine but became seriously involved with experimental psi research. In 1948, he set up a lab in Glen Cove, Maine, called the Round Table Foundation Laboratory of Experimental Electrobiolgy. The foundation had support from rich businessmen, political figures (including former vice president Henry Wallace), and an interested observer in military intelligence. Somewhere along the way Puharich had acquired

friends in high, dark places: “A friend of mine, an army colonel, who was Chief of the Research Section of the Office of the Chief of Psychological Warfare [OCPW], had dropped in to say hello.” This is Puharich, speaking of events in August 1952, quoted by Redfern from Puharich’s *The Sacred Mushroom: Key to the Door of Eternity* (Doubleday, 1959). The Army’s OCPW—established in early 1951 to organize, train, and support local populations in behind-the-lines resistance activities—was monitoring Puharich’s work and wanted a summary of the results. Now what was he doing?

Puharich—for some reason unknown to me—had the idea that our rudimentary psychic abilities could be enhanced if we were placed in an optimal environment. His guess for the best environment was a Faraday cage,



Eileen Garrett

an enclosed space shielded from electromagnetic influences. Into this Puharich placed someone who may have been America’s most gifted psychic at the time, Eileen Garrett (1893–1970). Others followed her in this experiment, but she was the best. To create a random, unpredictable target, Puharich selected the detection of cosmic ray bursts over a certain threshold that would trigger a signal in a detector. Garrett would

attempt to psychically detect when that signal was recorded. There were other controls and, despite the small number of test runs, the results were pretty impressive. At least the Pentagon thought so.

Puharich completed his analysis of the Garrett tests in late October 1952, and he sent in a summary of the work to OCPW (to his “colonel friend”). They wanted him to come to Washington and report on his work in person to the Research Section, which he did on November 24. In addition to Army Psychological Warfare, the CIA was also

in attendance, according to Redfern.

Another group that attended the meeting was Air Force OSI. I know that because, in a roundabout way, that’s how I ended up with a copy of the Puharich report. In the middle of the CUFOS Roswell research project, I had tried to help Kevin Randle and Don Schmitt by finding what I could about Wright-Patterson Air Force Base during those early years of Air Force UFO investigations. This led me immediately to the Air Materiel Command Chief of Intelligence at the time, Col. Howard “Mack” McCoy, and then to a search for his relatives. Mrs. McCoy was, blessedly, still alive, very proud of Mack’s accomplishments and his UFO work and, in order to help CUFOS with telling his story, gave Mark Rodeghier, on a visit to her home, a fair-sized box full of memorabilia from those times. In this material was a folder containing Puharich’s Pentagon report.

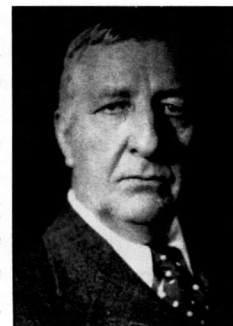


Col. Howard McCoy

McCoy had left Wright-Patterson by 1952 and was at the Pentagon working as director of a secret Department of Defense project called the Physical Security Equipment Agency. It had the job of ensuring that the equipment and devices used by intelligence operations (tape recorders, microphones, polygraphs, burglar alarms, and sound jammers) were “secure.” In that sense, it was the engineering and design end of the spy industry. McCoy, as director, was probably in attendance at the famous November meeting himself. He certainly had the report. Puharich felt that his presentation elicited little interest, but that was apparently just spooky disinformation. Because, as stated earlier, discussions began immediately (Redfern’s documents say “meetings” plural in November) and the intelligence groups, *all* of them apparently, were considering Soviet telepathic mind control.

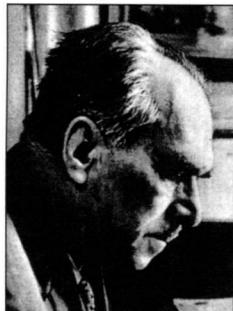
Something more than just Puharich’s studies with Eileen Garrett must have been boiling in the pot to cause this reaction, but that will take a better historian of psi research than me to ferret this out. Perhaps, though, you can tolerate a few related half-baked ideas.

Prior to World War II, psi research in this country was heading towards the laboratory through the efforts of William McDougall (1871–1938) at Duke University. If spectacular but idiosyncratic abilities such as those purportedly demonstrated by the wife of Upton Sinclair, Mary Craig Kimbrough (1883–1961) (see the book *Mental Radio*, 1930) could be made convincing in the laboratory, and if technological approaches like Puharich’s could find the optimizing variables, who knows how fast and far things could progress?



William McDougall

Around the same period of the *Mental Radio* claims, an Italian physicist named Ferdinando Cazzamalli (1887–1958) said he had discovered a brain state that served as the ground from which psychic ability originated. It was a state in which the brain produced brainwaves of about one centimeter in wavelength. One centimeter is near the center of the micro-



Leonid Vasiliev

wave region. The Russians became interested, and the Moscow Brain Research Institute, established in 1927 to examine the brains of such renowned revolutionaries as Lenin and other Russian public figures, began to look into the physical basis of telepathy. The Institute is said to have worked on this under the now well-known scientist Leonid Leonidovich Vasiliev (1891–1966)

until World War II, reportedly finding no leads. They *did*, however, begin to focus on the possible effects of electromagnetic radiation (which Puharich's tests were set up to block). In the Pentagon, they would be wondering how far the Soviets had really come.

These thoughts were passing through the minds of those in Air Force OSI, and McCoy's psi document is one example of it. Are there any others? Well, let's try this "flying leap." During 1952, the Air Force had a Special Studies Group in the office of the Chief of Intelligence, headed by Maj. Gen.



Stefan Possony

John A. Samford. The military head of the SSG was a Col. E. L. Sterling, but the de facto head was Dr. Stefan Possony (1913–1995). He was an expert in psychological warfare and one of the more zealous anticomunists around, an Austrian refugee who had fled the Nazis, an advisor to the French Air Ministry on psychological warfare, and a naturalized American citizen: All in all, a perfect recipe for obsessive paranoia, particularly

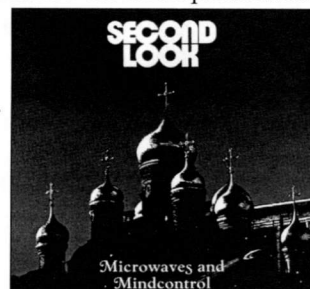
when you add in conservative Catholicism vs. the evil Soviet atheist empire. Possony eyed UFOs with suspicion—well, he eyed everything with suspicion. His SSG job was to assess UFOs in regard to the Soviet threat. He was also an expert in air power, and he fairly quickly dismissed the ideas that UFOs were some kind of advanced Soviet air technology. USAF Capt. Edward Ruppelt described Possony as sold on the reality of UFOs as a non-Soviet and non-U.S. technology, and would thump naysayers, such as Col. J. J. Porter, when they would try to deride the subject. Still, Possony thought that there was danger there, in the way that the Soviets might use the *idea* of the phenomenon.

Ruppelt remembers a Pentagon meeting in 1952 where Possony made Harvard astronomer Donald Menzel very nervous during his questioning. He thinks it was about the quality of Menzel's experiments that supposedly demonstrated that UFOs were illusions. Menzel remembered it

differently, and vividly. He recalled Possony pushing him on the consequences of being able to create such effective illusions, and whether talking about such things might encourage their use as a psychological warfare tool. Menzel said, "like Jesus Christ over the Kremlin?" When Possony nodded, Menzel became exasperated and stated that they weren't going to push him into some security-based situation where he couldn't publish his ideas on UFOs. Ruppelt said Possony went on to have Menzel investigated.

Possony believed that the Soviets were the Great Deceivers, using soft language to disguise brutal designs, and nearly always manipulating words and ideas. His speeches to public groups in the 1950s are full of this. He certainly knew what McCoy had learned about the telepathy and clairvoyance experimentation, and what the intelligence agencies were guessing and suspecting about contactees. What can we say about his thoughts? Maybe we know.

Just as McCoy stayed interested in UFOs long after they were a primary duty of his, so did Possony. Sitting in his office at Stanford University's Hoover Institution, he was keeping tabs on things paranormal and, among other things, reading *Second Look* magazine, which covered these topics. In the June 1979 edition he read an article by Stanton Friedman that mentioned what seemed to be microwave effects in many UFO encounters. This seems to have led him to James McCampbell's book, *UFology*, which emphasizes how microwaves might explain certain close-encounter phenomena. This then inspired Possony to write his own article, "Microwaves and Mind Control," in the December 1979 issue of *Second Look* (right).



Ufologically, the article is mainly about the possibility of creating glowing light forms that could defy gravity and inertia, and cause perceptual and physiological troubles in the witnesses. But I was intrigued by the rest of the article. Possony introduces it with a lengthy commentary about the Soviets microwaving the U.S. embassy in Moscow, and mentions that the CIA has been interested in this radiation's effect on the brain for a long time. And the title gives it away: The use of microwaves to somehow control minds is on *his* mind. He mentions that Ivan Pavlov conducted such research in Russia on animals in the 1930s. He notes that such radiation could alter human alpha rhythms, perhaps modifying them in deliberate ways. He speaks of "tuning" the mind. To what? Andrija Puharich always spoke of his research as an attempt to tune the mind to make it more receptive to psychic influences.

At the end of his article, Possony writes:

"Could the Soviets zap the entire U.S., as they zapped the U.S. embassy? Presumably yes. But would they go to the high expense of beaming microwaves from Russia to America for the purpose of creating a UFO craze or a mass anxiety neurosis?"

With this odd comment, Possony ends his article. He is not talking (directly) about the 1950s or contactees, but I believe it is very likely that those days and those thoughts had never left his mind: Soviet microwave radiation for mind control; tuning the mind's rhythms to enhance susceptibility to psi forces; use of (perhaps) sensitive, idealistic dupes to preach an antimilitary, anti-A-bomb, anticapitalist Space Philosophy. And, as a side effect, making light-form UFOs that move like magic.

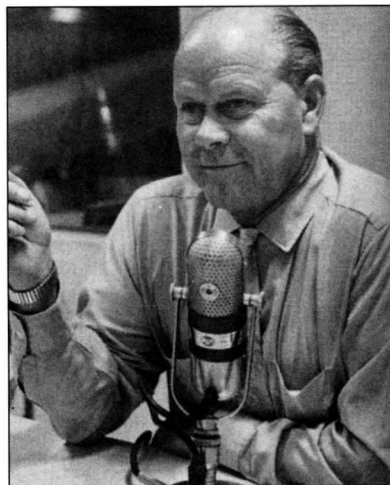
Redfern says that the intelligence community seriously considered the possibility that this is what happened with Adamski and George Van Tassel (1910–1978), who was even more loudly antiwar and anti-bomb than the Professor. Van Tassel even made a ludicrous run for president on a Peace ticket. He was followed by the even stranger Gabriel Green (first for senator, then president) with a radical economic theory that was promoted at Van Tassel's Giant Rock UFO conventions. Reading Redfern's article alone, I at first thought this theory of contactee behavior couldn't possibly have been taken seriously. Now, with Puharich, Vasiliev, McCoy, and Possony, I must admit that though *I* think it's colossally stupid, yes, I believe that the OSI, the CIA, and the FBI probably *were* serious.

I've got one last entanglement of Possony with UFOs and the intelligence wizards for your consideration. Possony was a mysterious attendee at the CIA-commissioned Robertson Panel on UFOs in January 1953 (perfect timing). Contributions to the panel by Possony and the other mysterious CIA operatives listed are not emphasized by the panel's recording secretary Frederick C. Durant and, in the case of Possony, nothing is written at all.

There have always been certain large and small mysteries about the panel. Some say it lasted five days, some four. I'll say it was four days, which matches Durant's summary. But even then the final day's discussions are extremely vague, giving one the impression that nothing much happened except editorial massaging of a complete report with recommendations that was written magically overnight. Possony is listed as an "interviewee," but nothing of his contribution is provided. Maybe he said nothing relevant, but that's doubtful. Note that after the scientists and the CIA technical people and the UFO Air Force officers stop talking about the UFO phenomenon, all the rest of the report is about managing the mind of the American public. The report, if it were directed towards an enemy, would be called a psychological warfare program. And of those people listed in the document, who among them was *the* PsyOps expert?

Pages of mind-managing tricks are put forward in the panel's report, including movies and television propaganda by Walt Disney. After the stuff about the general public, the report turns a suspicious eye on the civilian UFO investiga-

tion groups and suggests they be monitored "because of their potentially great influence on mass thinking if widespread sightings should occur." One group cited was the Aerial Phenomena Research Organization, which in 1953 was a tin-pot outfit run by Coral Lorenzen while she was still in Wisconsin. If they were worried about *her* being a "mass influence," then one can easily credit the report's authors with being worried about a much more spectacular figure such as Adamski.



George Van Tassel

And then there is this: "The apparent irresponsibility and the possible use of such groups for subversive purposes should be kept in mind." That's pure Possony. If he didn't say it, he must have telephoned it to the person who did.

I wonder, idly, if Possony or one of the CIA employees mentioned the going theory about the contactees to the panel. *That* would have stunned some of them stupid, I bet. And, if they had humility enough to admit that this was out of their field (very doubtful, I know), they might have felt that here was *another* reason entirely why they had to make UFOs seem empty and silly.

Later in that fateful year of 1953, Van Tassel claimed UFO contacts, published the news in the first volume of *Proceedings of the College of Universal Wisdom*, and wrote a letter to Wright-Patterson AFB telling his story. This last act made him one of three things: delusional beyond belief, the brassiest con man ever, or someone who honestly had some kind of strange experience. Most of us would select option number two. A few might pick number one. It appears that the OSI and FBI selected number three, smelling Russian involvement. By August 1954, someone informed on Van Tassel to the FBI as a likely Soviet spy because of his anti-American views (peace, universal harmony, no war, no H-bombs, no cancer-causing pollution, concern for the poor, etc.—"we don't believe in any of that." I can't help but remark how sad it was, maybe still is, that someone having such views can be an enemy of the state, but somehow that happened. Yes, yes, context, but it's still tragic that it occurred, and not just to UFO nuts.)

Van Tassel's extreme pronouncements against the bomb added fuel to the Soviet mind-manipulation theory, and even J. Edgar Hoover was sent a memo about it.

I suppose that as time went on, the absurd antics at Giant Rock out-sillied Disney, and the panel's (and the FBI's) job was done with very little effort on their part. Certainly the standing and status of UFOs took tremendous hits every time Van Tassel held a convention. He did more than almost anyone to reduce UFOs to a laughing matter in those early days.

Meanwhile, over on the psychic side, the spy community was still being regularly titillated by the potential

(continued on page 24)

THE SELDON UFO

BY TED BLOECHER AND SYLVIA MEAGHER

Editors Note: Today triangular or boomerang-shaped UFOs are common, but back in the Golden Age of UFO sightings, they were more unusual, though they did make an appearance now and then. In this report from the CUFOS files (originally a case from the National Investigations Committee on Aerial Phenomena), we present a close encounter sighting from 1972 of a triangular/wedge-shaped UFO with an odd superstructure (another version of this report was originally published in the NICAP *UFO Investigator*, February 1973). We also print this report as a bit of further homage to Ted Bloecher, who was one of the investigators.

This account concerns a sighting that occurred on October 9, 1972, near Seldon, Long Island. It was reported shortly afterwards to NICAP by one of the two witnesses, Mrs. Grace Clapp. We did our on-site investigation on November 19 of that year. This included retracing the route taken by the witnesses on the evening of their sighting, using their own vehicle. This allowed us to see what was visible from the car, estimate a sighting timetable, and also examine the point of closest observation, where Mrs. Clapp and her husband, Ralph, stopped to watch the UFO pass close by. Our conclusion was that the Clapps had a rather close encounter—on the order of several hundred feet—with an unidentified aerial object, origin unknown.

THE SIGHTING

Following supper on the evening of Monday, October 9, sometime close to 7:30 p.m., Ralph and Grace Clapp left

Ted Bloecher became interested in UFOs during the 1952 wave and was a cofounder of Civilian Saucer Intelligence in New York City. He was also associated with the National Investigations Committee on Aerial Phenomena. In the 1980s he retired from ufology and donated his files to CUFOS. Sylvia Meagher was a research analyst at the World Health Organization in New York and became an expert on the John F. Kennedy assassination.

their home in Smithtown, Long Island, to drive to the Coram Rug Works in Coram to return a carpet sample. They drove the approximately 10 miles in their 1969 Volkswagen bus. The night was clear and almost fully dark when they set out. To get to Coram, they picked up Route 25 (Middle Country Road) south of their home, which would take them directly to their destination.

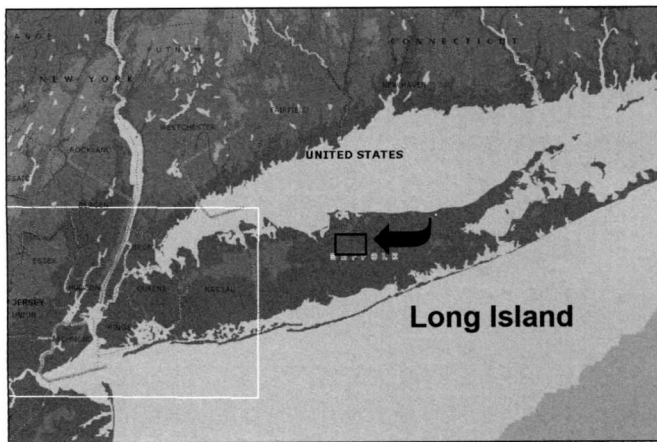
About a mile and a half east of the town of Centerreach, they both noticed a bright, white light low in the sky to the northeast (they were driving just north of due east at this point). It was similar to the bright landing light of an airplane. Neither immediately mentioned it to the other. While waiting at the next stoplight, the couple noticed that, unlike a plane, the light did not appear to be moving. Ralph asked Grace if she had noticed the light, and when she said she had, he suggested they keep it in sight.

The light was occasionally obscured by trees and buildings along Route 25, but was not difficult to spot as they kept driving east. A mile beyond where they had first spotted the light, following a short stretch of trees that hid it, Grace exclaimed, "The darn thing is moving!" Its apparent direction was toward them. "Suddenly, it was closer to us, and then we could see it was moving."

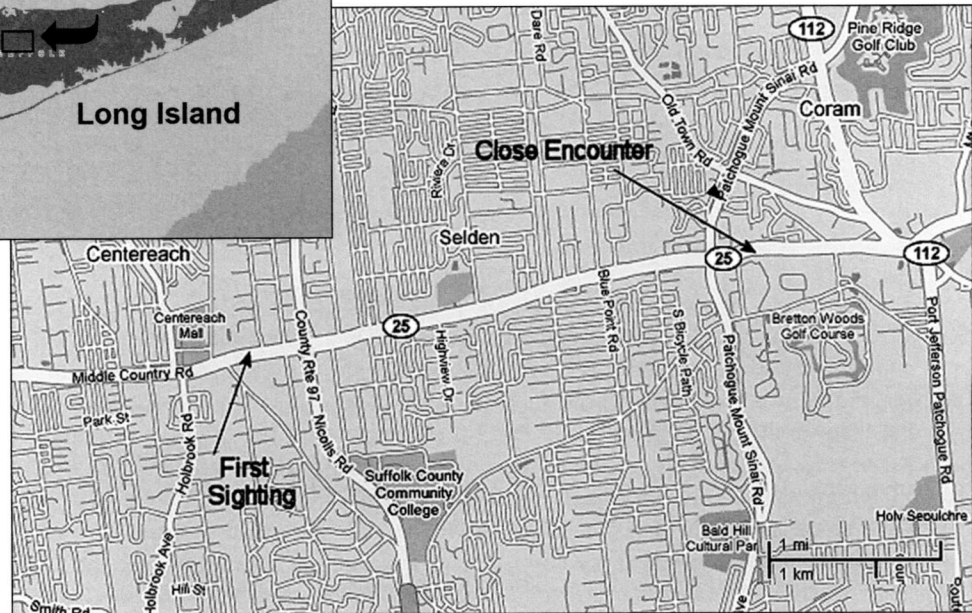
A few blocks after this, Grace noticed something else. In her words: "I said, 'Oh, now I see a red light,' and he said, 'I don't.' Then he looked up again and he says, 'Oh, yeah, now I see it too.' . . . Of course, he's driving while I'm watching this thing steadily," she added. Moderately heavy traffic along this route forced Ralph to keep his attention on the road. "And then," Grace continued, "a couple of seconds later, I saw a green light on the other side of it."

Elaborating on this detail, she said the red light was to the right of the bright, white light, and the green to the left. Both of them now noticed that the white light was pulsating noticeably; "like a heartbeat," as Grace put it, opening and closing her fist.

When they saw the red and green lights, both of them thought that it must be an airplane, but they kept on watching because the white light was so brilliant. Then, as they kept driving, Grace told her husband that "You know, I see



Map showing the general area of the Clapps' sighting, between Centereach and Coram, Long Island, New York.



a ring, the shape of a ring, or an outform." She gestured to us (TB/SM) indicating an arc that appeared laterally around the while light. Although it was indistinct at first, she finally said to her husband that she was sure she saw something with shape.

By this time they had passed the traffic light at Selden and were approaching a small hill that lies between Selden and Coram, their destination. As they came up to the hill, the lights were lost to view.

At the top of this hill there is a level stretch of highway somewhat less than a thousand feet in length, bordered on the north by trees and to the right by open fields extending a quarter mile or more to the south. There were also some abandoned buildings, but generally it is a relatively isolated, unsettled portion of the highway (most of the roads near this spot visible on the map of the sighting were not there in 1972).

THE CLOSE ENCOUNTER

The Clapps anticipated the reappearance of the light as they reached the top of the hill, but the trees along the north side blocked the view. Oddly (or not so much, if you've read enough UFO reports), while traffic had been fairly heavy up to now, there wasn't another car in sight when they got to the top.

At a point somewhat short of the halfway point along this hilltop segment of highway, the path of the light and that of the Clapps suddenly converged. They simultaneously saw the light as it hove into view above the treetops at an angle high overhead, a little forward and still to their left. Only now,

there was a dramatic change of appearance. Grace yelled to Ralph, "Pull off the road, that's no airplane!"

She noticed windows, with lights, but no wings. As she pressed her face against the windshield, her impression of the windows was that they were rectangular shaped. They were roughly spaced in a way that conformed to the object's shape. She was uncertain about how many windows she saw—five to ten—but she was certain that they were located on the bottom of the object, not the sides. The windows were white in color, and Grace compared them in brightness to a neighbor's window: "it was as if you were sitting here and looked over to the next block and the lady had her lights on in her room."

Having seen the windows himself, Ralph did stop the car, pulling over on a very narrow shoulder. The Volkswagen was partially over the edge of the road at a curve and was in a dangerous position, so he didn't get out. Instead, he opened his window and leaned his head out and craned his neck upward. He saw an elongated ellipse of lights, with a dark mass in between, and the bright, front light. He couldn't make out the exact shape of the object, but had the impression of a "dark body, curving backward."

He described the "windows" as two rows of five or six lights, "a row on either side forming an elongated ellipse," with the curved end forward. They were shaped like an elongated rectangle. He didn't see the red or green lights as it passed overhead. He estimated it was in view about 6 seconds, and that it subtended 8 to 10 inches at arm's length.

Meanwhile, Grace immediately got out of the vehicle to watch the object. From the embankment she could see several

things that her husband could not. She could see the whole object more clearly, which was “bat-shaped” or roughly triangular, with a rounded leading point and a straight trailing edge. Then, as the object continued to move to the southwest, she saw that on the object’s rear were two vertical antenna-like structures rising from the back top surface. They were at least as tall as the object was wide, and stretching across the top from one to the other was a thinner “pole” or some other structure. In Mrs. Clapp’s words:

There were these two great big antennas, or poles, sticking up, with what would be a considerably narrower one going across the top. . . . That gave it a very home-made appearance, in the rear, with the poles, because I said to myself, it looks like someone made it in their garage.

Grace kept yelling to her husband, describing what she could see, and couldn’t believe that he never got out of the car. As she said, “He looks back [now] and bangs his head against the wall every day!”

We asked Grace whether there was enough ambient light to see all this detail, and she explained, “Whatever the body was made out of was very dark. . . . It was either a very, very dark grey or black, and the poles were the same color. . . . It was darker than the sky.” But, she thought that there was some light reflected from the white light on the front of the object, and there was also a glow from the red and green lights, which she could now see again. After the object had passed to the west, the red light was on the left and the green on the right. These two lights were on the side edges of the object, toward the rear.

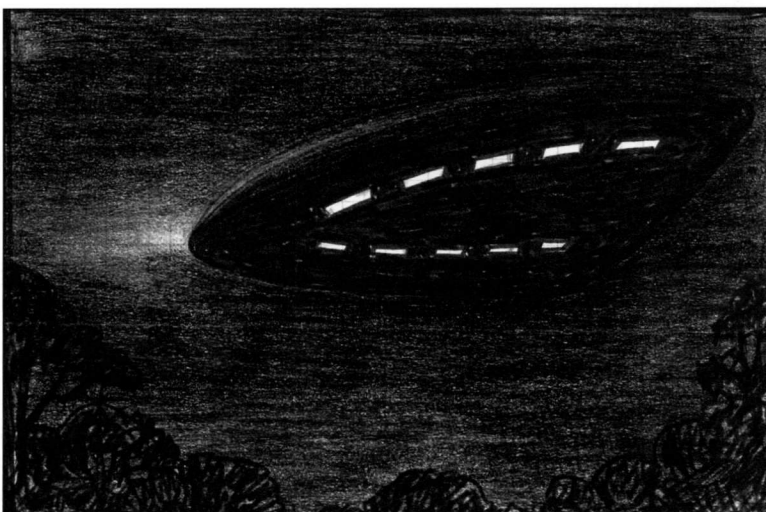
Regarding the object’s shape, Grace emphasized that, unlike a plane, this object was flat. “The thing . . . was as if you put two saucers together; naturally, you’re not going to have any sides.” Except that, unlike a saucer, this object was a triangular shape, with a rounded, leading point.

We asked Grace about the object’s apparent size at its closest point overhead. She gave an estimate of 26 to 30 inches in width at arm’s length when we visited the observation site with her. That is roughly three times that of her husband. Even if her husband’s estimate is closer to the actual size, the angle subtended was considerable (we calculate possible sizes below).

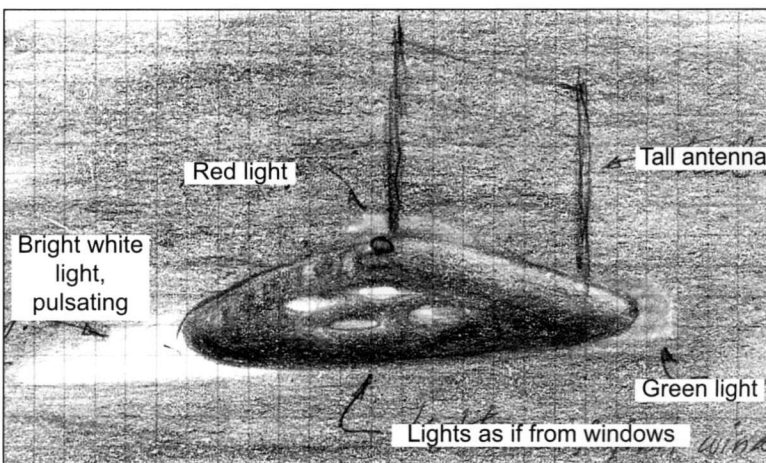
The couple could not accurately guess the object’s altitude without knowing its size. Ralph guessed based on several visual clues that it was somewhere between 200 and 1,000 feet high.



Light as first seen through front car windshield, heading east.



Object as seen by Ralph Clapp, almost directly overhead and slightly to one side. To be strictly accurate, the outside edge of the object was not seen as clearly by Mr. Clapp as depicted in this drawing, but that detail was added to make the position of the windows clear.



Object as seen by Grace Clapp as it was leaving to the west-southwest.

Grace based her estimate on the telephone poles along the road and believed it was several hundred feet in altitude, but no more (in her original letter to NICAP, she estimated the height at 200 to 300 feet).

One additional feature—or its absence—impressed Mrs. Clapp. As she watched the object, she was suddenly aware that she heard no motor sounds, as with a plane. Impressed by this, she strained to hear some evidence of noise, and said she did perceive a faint humming sound, just audible.

By this time a car was approaching from the east, and Ralph, concerned about the way the car was parked, summoned his wife into the VW, and they proceeded toward Coram, just a short distance farther along Route 25. Altogether, about 10 minutes had elapsed from the moment when they first saw the bright white light.

It took about two or three minutes to drive to the Coram Rug Works. After they parked, Grace immediately looked back toward the southwest to see if the object could still be seen. Weirdly, though, only the big white light could be seen. When we questioned her closely, she admitted that she couldn't swear what she saw then wasn't a bright star or planet. Jupiter set about three hours after the sun on October 9, 1972, and it would have been in approximately the right position to be confused for the light. And we know from long experience that witnesses, after their main sighting, often mistake other lights for a distant view of what they had seen up close.

Fortunately, the Clapps didn't much discuss the sighting on the drive home, and they were separated at the rug store (only Grace went into the store), so when they returned home they wrote down independent accounts of what they had observed. The drawings in this article were done by Mr. Clapp, who worked as the deputy town engineer for the township of Smithtown, and also as a landscape architect, and so was skilled at drawing. They spent a great deal of time getting accurate renditions of what each saw, so we can have confidence in the verisimilitude of these drawings.

DISCUSSION

We visited the Clapps at their home, and then redrove the route in their VW bus. The distance from first sighting the light to the top of the small hill is about three and one half miles. It took about 8 minutes to travel this distance, which was consistent with the couple's estimate of duration. Given the time they left home, and the time to get to the spot where the sighting began, the estimate of Mr. Clapp that they stopped about 7:55 p.m. to watch the object go overhead appears accurate.

The object was large, even using conservative estimates. If we use Ralph's estimate of about 10 inches in width at an arm length's distance of 30 inches, then if the object was 200 feet high, it would have been about 67 feet in width. At 500 feet, about 167 feet in width, and at 1,000 feet, the outer estimate of altitude, about 333 feet in width. Grace's estimate of apparent width would triple these size estimates at the same height.

We did contact local airports on Long Island, and found no advertising planes that operated out of them on this date, and no flights that would correspond to the time and direction of what the Clapps observed.

Thus this sighting remains unexplained by any conventional device without disregarding certain key details in their descriptions. As Mrs. Clapp said, in her very distinctive way, "If that thing was an advertising plane, it sure wasn't getting the message across."

IUR EDITOR'S CONCLUDING REMARKS

This little report has many features that make it interesting and are consonant with other sightings of large wedge- or triangular-shaped UFOs. This includes how it moved, the time of its appearance, its size, and the noise it emitted,

First, it was large, probably at least 100 feet across, much larger than your standard disc-shaped UFO. The boomerang-shaped UFOs seen less than a decade later nearby in Westchester County, New York, and western Connecticut were at least this size.

Second, the UFO moved steadily and fairly slowly, and it moved continuously across the sky, in a trajectory that a terrestrial vehicle could emulate. Most large triangular UFOs are seen for several minutes, if not longer (as was the Tinley Park Triangle in the southern Chicago suburbs in 2004–2005), and don't engage in the extremely rapid motions and right-angle turns reported for other UFOs.

Third, the Clapps saw their UFO when it was dark. Essentially no sightings of large triangular-shaped UFOs occur in daylight, for whatever reason.

Fourth, these large UFOs do make noise, but not enough to keep them afloat by conventional means. Instead, the faint hum reported by Mrs. Clapp is typical.

The weird superstructure on the back upper surface of the UFO is intriguing. We are especially taken by Mrs. Clapp's remark that "it looks like someone made it in their garage." While witnesses don't always make that colorful an observation, in some cases (and not just triangular UFOs), the objects do have odd protrusions and protuberances that don't fit our image of a sleek aerial vehicle. In this instance, the two vertical and one horizontal pole remind one of the masts used on naval vehicles for radio communication, or some radar arrays. But could this be their purpose?

And then there are the red and green lights, which are reminiscent of aircraft anticollision lights. They were placed on the correct sides of the UFO. And yet, why would a UFO display lights in the same pattern as standard aircraft? Was this whole thing a display, as many would contend, to catch the attention of the witnesses but offer only confusing clues and odd details? Notice how the UFO, at first several miles distant, went eventually almost directly over the Clapps vehicle, affording them a close view so that it was completely obvious that it wasn't a plane. Coincidence or part of the plan? But, what is the plan? ♦

IN PRAISE OF TED BLOECHER

BY MICHAEL D. SWORDS

I have mused upon, and occasionally been asked the question, “who have been the most influential persons in the history of ufology?” My answer has always been Donald Keyhoe first, then on to J. Allen Hynek, James McDonald, Edward Ruppelt, Jacques Vallee, Aimé Michel, and Coral Lorenzen. Those names, and others, still stand. But, I’ve been reading the files of Ted Bloecher recently and have been thinking anew about this question.

Over many years, the sacred word has been uttered to me of the intensity of McDonald, the adamant fortitude of Keyhoe, the open-minded creativity of Vallee, the life-long persistence of Hynek, the honesty of Ruppelt, the wisdom of Michel—all true. And a great deal of all that was personified by Ted Bloecher.

People speak in awe of the fierce power of McDonald. I agree. But Bloecher makes all that seem like an episode in his own ufological life. Don’t laugh or cringe. Who surveys a whole wave, as Bloecher did with the 1947 wave, newspaper by newspaper, then begins 1952 as well? Who initiates HUMCAT, the universal catalog of all humanoid sightings? Who really begins the “modern” movement of abductions research? Who is there, at the center of a flurry of correspondence and information, at CSI-NY, at NICAP, at the Humanoid Study Group, year after year after year? When we begin to get too proud of ourselves for our own efforts, remember Ted Bloecher and get some perspective.

People speak of the creativity of Vallee. I wholeheartedly agree and applaud. But Ted Bloecher shines as brightly. Read his letters, his case notes: There is the open, objective mind, almost always before any (knowledgeable and rational) researcher was there. His eyes were alert for the areas of high strangeness. He, despite some excessive conservatism from colleagues and excessive foolishness from ufological camp followers, walked a beautiful central line. The reported details were there—no matter their strangeness. The witnesses were just as good as any others—why arbitrarily dismiss their testimonies? Ted Bloecher fought

for the strange report, the case elements that were too much for anyone else. And, with the honesty of Ruppelt and the wisdom of Michel, he stared any claim and claimant down, and patiently, with discipline, said, “Show me.”

You should read the Ted Bloecher of the mid-to-late 1970s, as I have been doing. The whole saga of the CE3 to CE4 transformation is embodied there. It’s an astounding

story, full of stunning experiences, avalanching over Ted and his colleagues. Weird and wild thinking is flying about, and colleagues are rapidly grabbing at this or that bit in their race to find meaning. But not Ted Bloecher. He stands in the middle of the vortex, filtering and transmitting it all, honestly, and battling it with his analytical mind to try to discern where the solid foundations lie. In the end, I believe, some errors were made, as the blinding flow of encounters and the press of fellow travelers sprinting towards solutions were too difficult to keep at unemotional distance. Still, what a tower of strength and reason!

Knowing what I know (albeit not much personally) about Ted, I would imagine that he would laugh a bit at himself as a “tower of strength and reason.” I’ve read his frequent—and often hilarious—side comments on other researchers’ outrageous opinions and dishonesties. They are another sign of Ted’s explosive caring about truth in our field, and thoroughly admirable. But, I never saw this powerful emotion he carried cloud his thoughts or his meditations in the correspondence files.

Another sign that Ted kept his eye on the prize, when others did not: I have in my left hand as I write this his letter to Judi Hatcher of November 29, 1966. He is writing from Chicago, where his theater group was playing. Of course, in the off hours, he was, as always, “at ufology.” One of the activities was meeting with Hynek and Vallee. Ted spent the whole time trying to be productive and oriented toward the future and the best functioning of ufology. While another hero, Jim McDonald, was out-of-control vindictive to Hynek (wanting to trash him for his past sins of cowardice and wimpy unassertiveness at Project Blue Book, as I know because I’ve been reading



McDonald's files right alongside), Ted was ready to leave that unproductive past and with no feeling of any need for calling out, try to clear away misunderstandings, calm emotions, and begin useful work. McDonald could never let any of that go. Ted Bloecher was a bigger man. It didn't make any difference who was right. Like in sports, if we had a fight on the floor, the thing was: "All right, now, let it go. We've got a game to play."

Ted Bloecher was, and is, a very rare person indeed. An artist with an analytical, disciplined mind—emotionally intense but capable of saying "not so fast"—open-minded to the unthinkable, but capable of tossing away the dishonest and the foolish—I am not sure that we've had anyone remotely like him. And, as a point of shame and telling criticism about our field, I will bet that the vast majority of

persons supposedly interested in UFOs don't even know about him and his accomplishments.

This little essay has been written in profound appreciation of someone who may just have been the best we've ever had, but my rambling is in opposition to all Ted's behavior stood for, so let me stop here. Why did I write this homage? Well, I believe that, with all the nasty contentiousness that I've been reading in the historical documents of the field, Ted is "clean air," a straight-shooter who doesn't let his ego damage his work. And, I thought it would be nice if someone gave one of the good guys full praise before they were in the sod and couldn't appreciate it as much. As a good Catholic boy, I'm not certain if you can still then read your press clippings. Anyway: Ted Bloecher, I give you what little honor is mine to give. Ufology owes you a lot. ♦

BOOK REVIEW

UFOs and Nukes: Extraordinary Encounters at Nuclear Weapons Sites, by Robert Hastings. The author, 2008. \$23.95. ISBN 978-1-4343-9831-4. ufohastings.com.

This voluminous book documents the many instances of reported UFO sightings over nuclear facilities. Most alarmingly, it also discusses the possible effects of the UFO upon the functioning of various military equipment, especially nuclear missiles and their control technology. The amount of detail included is impressive—the book is more than 600 pages long—as Hastings has decided to give the reader enough information to form his own judgment about these cases.

Before I venture into the core of the book's argument, I'd like to explain why I'm impressed with this book and believe Hastings can be trusted. When I'm reviewing books, I take a look at the things that I know first, as I can't double-check on the author's other research. Has the author gotten that information correct? If he has, it adds a note of credibility to his work and if he hasn't, then I begin to wonder what else he might have gotten wrong.

Hastings has a chapter on the Roswell UFO case, and it was here that I could make my analysis, given my own extensive investigations on Roswell. Hastings interviewed Chester Lytle, who had a distinguished career as a scientist serving the government in a number of high-level and important ways. Hastings wanted to know about his involvement with atomic energy and what he might know about UFO sightings near nuclear plants or facilities. During one of those discussions, Hastings reports that, with no prompting from him, Lytle moved on to the Roswell UFO crash and told Hastings that William Blanchard, who had command of

the 509th Bomb Group in Roswell at the time of the crash, confirmed the alien nature of the event.

I have known Robert Hastings for nearly 20 years and I have always been impressed with his integrity and his intellect. I knew Chester Lytle for a long time. He was a man of impressive credentials who had no reason to embellish his position and suggest UFO knowledge if he had none. In

fact, to do so could cause him some embarrassment, but more importantly, could damage his business. In other words, talking about flying saucers wouldn't have done him much good and certainly could have hurt him.

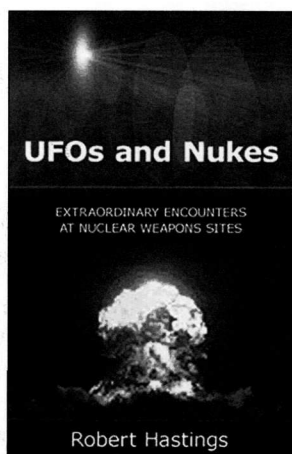
Lytle told Hastings that in February 1953, with Blanchard now a general officer, the pair was in Alaska while Lytle's wife was in Chicago about to give birth. Lytle was desperate to get home, and Blanchard said that they could take an Air Force aircraft to Illinois, land at one of the bases close to Chicago, and Lytle could get home from there.

While on the flight, somehow the subject of UFOs came up, maybe because of a couple of sightings at Elmendorf Air Force Base near Anchorage sometime earlier. Blanchard then told Lytle that an alien craft had crashed near Roswell. According to Hastings, Blanchard told Lytle that alien bodies had been recovered.

Surprised by this, Hastings asked Lytle, "Blanchard actually told you that the Roswell object was an alien spacecraft."

Lytle said, "Oh, absolutely."

In a break with the traditional story, Blanchard said that some of the bodies had gone originally to Muroc Army Air Field (now Edwards Air Force Base), but that they all wound up at Wright Field.



Of course, it fails on one point and that is that we can't verify it with either Lytle or Blanchard. Both men are dead. The documentation that exists is quite limited and subject to various interpretations. But so far as I know, Hastings got the Roswell information correct. My own investigations and interviews with Lytle confirm that he did know Blanchard, Lytle did work on something in Alaska, and he did get a quick trip home. The one thing that Lytle had not said in my presence was that Blanchard told him there were four bodies. But Lytle had told me, as well as other sources, that Blanchard had suggested that the crash was alien in origin. So, I'm reassured by this account from Hastings's book.

Now I could look at his work from another point of view and that is as a military officer, familiar with military secrecy and the way that the military operates. Has Hastings gotten that information correct as well?

I noticed that he took pains to document the sightings that he reports. He is involved with the debate over the validity of the Big Sur, California, missile test in September 1964. He provides us with a glimpse of the official investigation that seems to include CIA agents who cautioned the witnesses to say nothing and then took part of the motion picture footage that showed the UFO attacking the missile, causing it to fail.

Hastings has copies of letters and reports from former Air Force officer and later Doctor Robert Jacobs, and the replies from Major and later Doctor Florenze H. Mansmann Jr. Hastings notes that Jacobs has suggested the missile test was sabotaged by a UFO and Mansmann agreed with him. Lee Graham, another UFO researcher, supplied Hastings with copies of the correspondence in which all this is laid out.

Hastings interviewed Jacobs in 1986. He learned that he (Jacobs) and Mansmann "were obviously still stunned by, and marveling over, the Big Sur UFO incident—some 20 years later."

Jacobs wrote an article for the *MUFON UFO Journal* in January 1989, which Mansmann said was factual. Mansmann made it clear that the UFO was of the "classic disc, the center seemed to be a raised bubble . . . the entire lower saucer shape . . . was glowing and seemed to be rotating slowly."

Hastings also mentions that CSICOP, now known as the Committee for Skeptical Inquiry, published an article in the *Skeptical Inquirer* suggesting that the UFO and the beams seen coming from it were part of the reentry plume and from small explosive charges used to release the decoys on the missile. But then Hastings makes it clear that the author of that article was unaware that Mansmann had endorsed the Jacobs article, that the *Skeptical Inquirer* author had misinterpreted or misread part of the Jacobs article, and later seemed uninterested in either hearing about that, or correcting his errors.

What caught my interest in this particular story, which I can't tell completely here for reasons of space (but see Hastings's article, "A Shot Across the Bow: Another Look at the Big Sur Incident," in *IUR* 31, no. 3, pp. 3–11, 20–24) was the appearance of the late Philip J. Klass. As was his

nature, Klass hounded Jacobs after the publication of his story, asking all sorts of questions about it, which was fair enough. But then, according to Hastings, Klass took it a step too far. Klass wrote a derisive letter to the chairman of Jacobs's department at the University of Maine in which he questioned Jacobs's fitness as a representative of the academic community.

This was an outrageous attempt to suppress UFO information, but one that Klass took on numerous occasions. Klass would write to witnesses' and researchers' employers, often attempting to get them into some kind of trouble. Klass, it seems, had decided he was the arbiter of all things ufological, and if someone disagreed with him, then that person should suffer the consequences. I point this out simply because this was a dirty trick to play on someone who was attempting to report as accurately as possible his UFO sighting and to point out that there are consequences for telling a UFO-related tale.

The real thrust of the book, however, is its investigation and recounting of UFO sightings that correspond to incidents at nuclear sites, including storage facilities and missile sites. Obtaining information on these events is difficult because of the inherent high classification of the material. Almost anything to do with the nuclear capability of the United States is classified and those entrusted with the responsibility understand that. They are reluctant to talk because they do not want to violate the oaths they took.

For example, Hastings interviewed David H. Schuur, who was a missileman crewmember in Minot, North Dakota, in the 1960s. When Hastings talked to him, Schuur said, "Well, we were basically told, way back when, that it was classified information and, you know, it didn't happen and don't discuss it."

Not surprising, considering Schuur was involved with the nuclear strike capability of the United States. Schuur told Hastings about a series of sightings of a large, bright object that was maneuvering through the missile field. He said that the topside security—the Air Police who were guarding the facilities—were making the visual reports of the UFO.

Schuur continued, saying that as the object moved to each of the missiles in his flight (separated by many miles), maybe six of ten, or seven of ten, they began to receive "spurious indications on our consoles." As the object moved to the next missile, the erratic indications on the first would disappear and then appear at the next.

The crucial point is that Schuur said, "We had to activate the 'Inhibit' switch because we got 'Launch in Progress' indicators." Schuur was stating that the UFO was somehow giving the missiles a launch signal. He also told Hastings that they had never before received the Launch in Progress signal.

Finding the corroborating documentation is equally difficult because it too is classified. Quite early in the book he explains that many of his FOIA requests about the incidents are returned saying that no permanent records of the events have been kept by the various Air Force or intelligence orga-

nizations. Hastings writes, “it’s quite obvious that important documentation is still being kept from public scrutiny.”

I would note that it’s probably restricted using the blanket “national security” excuse. National security considerations trump FOIA, and that, I believe, is as it should be.

There is some documentation for these UFO sightings at the Strategic Air Command bases. For example, from the Project Blue Book files, Hastings reports on a series of different sightings over Minot. These include radar returns in B-52s as well as visual sightings from the ground, explained by the Air Force as ionized air, a theory that had a short life when it was realized that ionized air doesn’t necessarily glow. If that were a viable explanation, radar at all airports would have similar problems on a regular basis.

It is reassuring that there is documentation in the Project Blue Book files about these events and there is eyewitness testimony from those involved, who were recently telling UFO researchers what they had seen and done in 1964. This is the type of case that is difficult to dismiss. Not only are the Project Blue Book files, originally classified as secret, now available, but some of the witnesses are talking about what they saw.

Hastings, of course, provides the footnotes and source information on all these cases so that the reader is able to find the truth for him or herself. He provides an impressive array of documentation.

If I have a complaint about the book, it surfaces in the chapter on mutilations. Clearly Hastings believes that some unknown extraterrestrial agency is responsible for the deaths of thousands of animals, most of them in Colorado, New Mexico, Wyoming, Idaho, and Montana. Hastings writes about the report by former FBI agent Kenneth Rommel, who was selected to investigate these deaths. Rommel concluded that there were some strange aspects to the deaths but the cattle weren’t being killed by extraterrestrials. There were terrestrial explanations, according to Rommel, but Hastings disagrees with that. This material didn’t really need to be in a book titled *UFOs and Nukes*.

But if there is a real problem with the book for the serious reader, it’s the lack of an index. Hastings told me that he ran out of time and needed to get the manuscript to the publisher. In later editions, he hopes to have an index, and it will really help because the book is filled with names, places, and events.

Over all, this is the sort of book needed by the UFO field as we attempt to move from the anecdotal into the scientific. We need to provide source information, which Hastings does, we need to verify the information, which Hastings does, and we need to provide documentation, which Hastings does.

He has given us both sides of the controversies he studies, and provided documentation and references for the interested reader to learn more. He is sure of his position, based on the hundreds of interviews he conducted, and the hundreds of documents he has seen, and the weak arguments marshaled against him. This is a book that takes us through much of the UFO phenomenon and it is a must for everyone who has an interest in UFOs.

If there are flaws in it, they are minor and grow out of the constant debunking efforts that all of us have faced as we attempt to get at the real truth. This is a worthy effort and one that will stand the test of time.—Kevin Randle. ♦

CHALLENGES—continued from page 5

and following projects purely because they seemed a way to understand more about the natural world. There was, admittedly, a certain conflict of interest because making acclaimed discoveries could be good for one’s prestige and career, but the limited rewards on offer didn’t make those conflicts of interest too influential. Disputes about who discovered something first were waged largely for reasons of ego and personal competitiveness.

But starting in the mid-20th century, science became “big,” research required increasingly large amounts of financial and infrastructure support, applications could make a discoverer wealthy in short order in fields like computers and molecular biology, and conflicts of interest have become very prominent in science. Together with that, there have been many incidents of scientific fraud, faking results, stealing other people’s work, and so on—to the extent that there’s now a burgeoning academic industry in research ethics, bioethics, and the like, holding conferences about those things, publishing journals and books about them.

And the resistance that mainstream consensus has always offered to startlingly new ideas and evidential claims has become terribly strong, because a mainstream consensus can harness support from granting agencies, journals, and the media, so that in an increasing number of fields there now exist what I’ve called “knowledge monopolies” and “research cartels.” In several cases, the mainstream consensus is clearly contradicted by published data in mainstream scientific journals, yet the monopolies are maintained by censorship and persecution. I’ve seen that at first hand in the case of AIDS, where the evidence seems to me conclusive that HIV is not its cause (see my HIV/AIDS Skepticism blog at hivskeptic.wordpress.com, which expands on the ideas presented in my book, *The Origin, Persistence, and Failings of HIV/AIDS Theory*, McFarland, 2008); and I’ve seen it at rather close second hand in the case of drug approval and marketing, and I’ve seen it at second hand in the cases of cold fusion and global warming.

So we should bask in our amateur status, and be conscious of its advantages.

It’s just great to be an amateur researcher, free to follow whatever fascinating leads appeal to us, free to make mistakes, but also free to pursue the really long shots, the things that will really make a difference when we come to understand them. It’s like the old story: Professional scientists have to fish where they know there are fish, even if they’re tiddlers and hardly worth eating; but we amateurs are free to go fishing where no one has ever before seen a fish, because if and when we do catch one, it’s a whopper and makes history! ♦

INFLUENCES ON OPINION ABOUT ETI AND UFOs

BY MARK RODEGHIER

The ongoing public interest in UFOs is mirrored by the TV documentaries, radio programs, and books about the subject that continue to be produced. Other measures of our enthusiasm are public opinion polls and surveys, which are commissioned because the news media and other organizations think that UFO stories will increase viewers or readers, and whose results underscore the fascination with extraterrestrials and UFOs (conflated in the public's mind, if not that of the scientific and media establishment).

In May 2008, a nationwide poll was conducted by the Scripps Howard News Service and Ohio University, under a grant from the Scripps Howard Foundation, that included a few questions about intelligent life elsewhere and possibly visiting Earth. The sample size of 1,003 was sufficiently large to allow for various types of analyses, and the margin of error is around 3% for the whole file, but larger for subgroups. You can read stories based on the survey at these links: www.scrippsnews.com/node/34757/ and www.scrippsnews.com/node/34758/.

In this article, I present some of the responses to the Scripps survey and compare them to the results from similar questions on other polls. Thomas Hargrove, from Scripps Howard, kindly supplied the original data file to me. This has allowed me to do some original analysis about how such demographic factors as age, gender, and political outlook relate to attitudes about ETI and UFOs. Questions about politics were at the core of this survey, given that it was conducted in the spring of 2008, and that gives us the opportunity to see how political views are associated with UFO attitudes.¹

BELIEF IN ETI

Questions about a belief in extraterrestrial intelligence have been asked of the American public since at least the mid-1960s. By the early 1970s, agreement that ETI existed had stabilized around 50% and hasn't gone much higher since. (For a summary of poll results on belief in ETI as of the early 1990s, see *Evolution of Public Opinion on UFOs*,

by Robert J. Durant, *IUR* 18, no. 6, pp. 9–13, 20–23. I also drew on this article for its summary of attitudes about UFOs.) We can speculate as to why belief hasn't continued to increase, given all the findings about extrasolar planets, the evolution of life on earth, galactic habitability zones, and the like. One plausible answer is that there is a great distinction between extraterrestrial life and *intelligent* life. We can judge that life is reasonably common but believe that its development into intelligent life is rare. (The book *Rare Earth: Why Complex Life is Uncommon in the Universe*, by Peter Ward and Donald Brownlee, makes the scientific case for this line of thought).

For example, the SETI program, no matter what its proponents may say, has been a dismal failure, and they have no evidence for the existence of ETI, while at least the UFO field has plenty of (mostly) strong anecdotal evidence that points to ETI. But the SETI program gets more mainstream respect, and its lack of success may have contributed to public unwillingness to grant even more support for the existence of ETI. There are other possible reasons, some of which we explore below.

As with so many national surveys today, the Scripps Howard poll was conducted by telephone, so the response choices had to be relatively simple and limited to reduce the cognitive burden on the respondents.² Consequently, the questions about belief had the three choices of Very Likely, Somewhat Likely, and Unlikely. There is also a Don't Know option that was recorded if the respondent said he couldn't decide or had no opinion. For most of the analyses, Don't Know responses will be dropped (considered missing), which simplifies data presentation, although initially I will list them to show the spread of opinion.

The exact question used on the Scripps Howard survey was "Here are some questions about life on other planets. Do you think it is very likely, somewhat likely or unlikely that there is intelligent life on other planets?" The results are displayed in Table 1 on the next page.

Several previous survey questions simply ask whether or not a person believes in the existence of ETI, not its likelihood. For comparability, then we should group the two categories of likely and somewhat likely. Using all the responses yields a total of 55.8% who say that ETI is

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Response	Percentage	Percentage (minus don't know)
Likely	25.6	28.2
Somewhat likely	30.2	33.3
Unlikely	35.0	38.6
Don't know/other	9.2	--

Table 1. Belief in extraterrestrial intelligence

likely; dropping the Don't Know responses yields a total of 61.5% who say that ETI is likely, among those with an opinion. These results are in line with previous surveys and are consistent with the essential static nature of belief in ETI for the past quarter century.

Among what groups is belief in ETI higher? For data exploration, I've grouped the two categories of somewhat likely and likely and dropped those without an opinion.

Gender. Consistent with almost all other past studies, males have a higher level of belief in ETI than females, 66.9% to 55.9%.³ There are many suggested factors underlying this difference, such as educational level or general interest in science and space.

Age. With the exception of young adults (24 and under), there is a steady rise in belief with increasing age, from 54.1% for those 25–34 years old, to 67.4% for those 55–64. Then there is a large drop to 52.1% for those 65 and above. Baby Boomers grew up during the Space Age and also lived during the high point of UFO sightings in this country (the 1950s through the early 1970s), and it is plausible that this early exposure to ETI-related evidence or events may have increased their belief. This pattern is also consistent with what we have observed from visitors and correspondence to CUFOS (and the gray hair of CUFOS board members and associates).

Region. There are differences in belief in ETI by region (see Figure 1). Those in the west have the highest level of belief in ETI, while those in the Midwest have the lowest (the difference is 16.5%, which is substantial). What might cause this disparity? We can all become amateur sociologists or social psychologists at this point. The west is associated with individualism (and in California, with esoteric beliefs), so

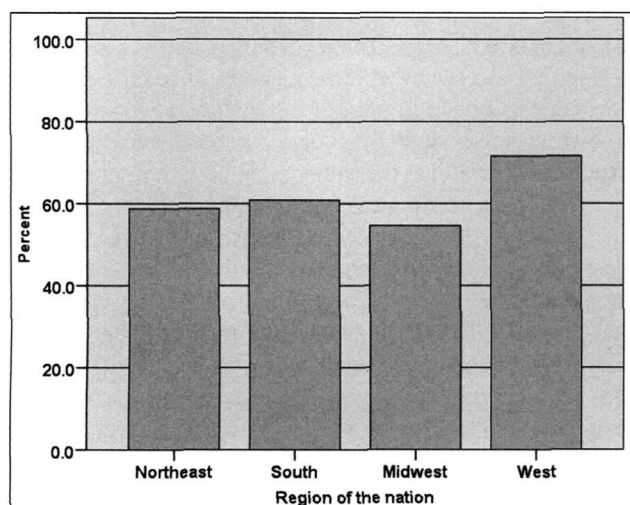


Fig. 1. Belief in ETI by region

perhaps this difference reflects the general open-mindedness of those who live in the west. But it could also be caused by other differences, including education level, location of residence (urban, suburban, or rural), and religious and political beliefs.

Residential location. Living in a city might make it more difficult to have a UFO experience, but should it affect your attitude about ETI? The answer, at least from these data, is that residential location has no direct relationship to ETI belief. You might be saying, "Sure, that makes sense," but we need to reflect a bit more on this. It is well-known that the demographic characteristics of people who live in cities are different than those in suburbs, who in turn are different than those in rural areas. And if demographic characteristics eventually help us to understand what factors influence belief in ETI, then there might certainly be differences in attitude related to where someone lives—not necessarily *caused* by where you live but instead a by-product of the sorting that goes on when people choose where to live. We'll keep this in mind.

Education. There is normally a pattern that those with more education have a higher level of belief in UFOs, but what about ETI? In these data, we find a weak relationship, but not quite as expected. The group with the lowest level of belief is those with some college (53.5%). All the other groups, including those with a high school or less education, have somewhat higher levels of belief. This one is difficult to figure out, but we can take the additional step of seeing whether there is an interaction between education and gender.

When statisticians say they have found an interaction, they simply mean that the effect of one variable is dependent on another variable. And that is what I discovered here, as evidenced in Figure 2. Notice how the level of belief for females is basically similar across educational levels, but there are larger differences for males, with the some college group again having the lowest level of belief. This is an interaction because there is no statistical relationship between education and belief for females but there is one for males.

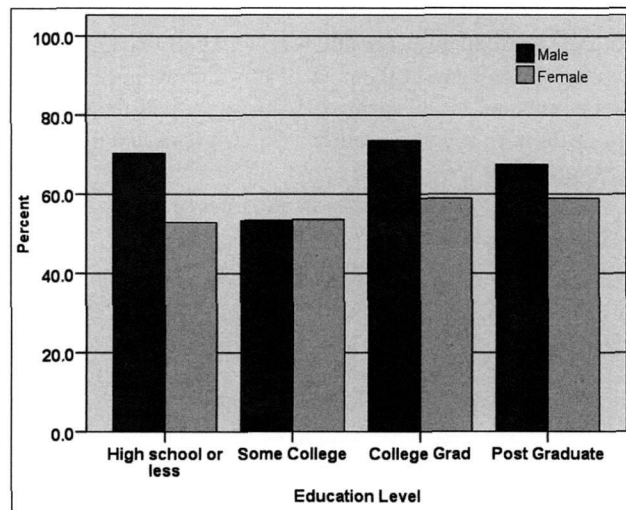


Fig. 2. Belief in ETI by education level and gender

Why does education have an effect for males, but not for females? I'll leave that to your contemplation for the moment.

Political position. The Scripps Howard poll asked questions about politics, so naturally it asked about a respondent's political position and party affiliation. We will use the question that asked for political position on a scale from very conservative to very liberal. There was a strong relationship such that liberals and those who professed to be middle-of-the-road have much higher levels of belief than conservatives. (Those who were very conservative had the lowest level of belief, at 47.2%; those who were very liberal had the highest at 68.7%.)

This pattern is also not surprising to those who follow the debates about various scientific controversies and the opposition to such things as the theory of evolution or global warming. But, is it being conservative itself, or liberal, along with each position's associated ideas, that make someone less, or more, open to a belief in ETI? To delve further, we can look at political position and belief separately by residential location to seek an interaction. The results show some exceptions to the overall pattern. For example, the pattern of less belief among conservatives completely disappears for those who live in suburbs: There is no difference in level of belief by political position. The greatest difference occurs for those who live in small cities, with belief among conservatives (46.9%) very much lower than among liberals (80.8%). The differences still exist among rural respondents and those in large cities, but they are smaller.

What is it about the suburbs that would mitigate the effect of political view? Or rather, who exactly is living in the suburbs compared to everywhere else? These statistical nuances remind us that public opinion is complex and that the patterns reported are often not the same in subgroups. This is true for political opinions about candidates and issues, and it is also true for attitudes about scientific issues.⁴

Religious affiliation. Religion, or the lack thereof, does make a difference. Those who profess no religion have the highest level of belief (68.6%), while Protestants have the lowest level (54.7%). Statistically, those with no religion are not different than Catholics (65.8%) or all others (60.0%). A priori, we would expect that religious beliefs may lead some to reject the possibility of extraterrestrial life, or certainly *intelligent* extraterrestrial life, and that appears to be verified.

But, there is another interaction at work. The survey includes the question, "Do you consider yourself born again?" (38.3% of the sample said "yes"). For Protestants who answer in the affirmative, belief in ETI drops to 41.0%, but for those Protestants not born again—Lutherans, Methodists, etc.—belief is 72.2% and indistinguishable from those of other religions or those with no religion. Being born again is an indication of belonging to a fundamentalist and evangelical Protestant denomination, and those groups are associated in the public mind with an aversion to some scientific teachings, and consonant with that is a lower belief in ETI.

And returning to our analysis above, if we examine the three-way relationship of born again, residential location, and belief in ETI, there is *no difference* in belief in ETI by location for those who are not born again. The differences in belief in ETI by location appear to be driven by differences in who lives where. In this sample, there are far more respondents who say they were born again in small cities and in rural areas than in either large cities or the suburbs.

BELIEF THAT ETI HAS VISITED EARTH

The second key question on the survey was about UFOs, if asked a bit vaguely. It was, "Do you think it is very likely, somewhat likely, or unlikely that intelligent life from other planets has visited Earth?" An oddity of this wording is that nowhere is the word "UFO" mentioned. That must have been deliberate, but it is conceivable that intelligent ETs could have visited Earth and not been spotted or detected, especially if their visits have been few. However, in the context of the first question and the general tenor of our times, we can fairly safely conclude that those answering that a visit is likely will have had UFO reports on their mind. This ambiguity does illustrate the tricky problem of writing survey questions, where you can't clarify things as in ordinary conversation.

As should be logically true, a smaller percentage of respondents said it was likely or somewhat likely that ETI has come to Earth compared to simple belief in ETI. A total of 33.1% thought an ETI visit was likely; using only the valid responses increases this to 37.4%.⁵

Response	Percentage	Percentage (minus don't know)
Likely	12.4	14.0
Somewhat likely	20.7	23.4
Unlikely	55.7	62.7
Don't know/other	11.2	--

Table 2. Belief that extraterrestrial intelligence has visited Earth

When other polls have asked an analogous question, the wording has not been comparable. Gallup usually asks whether "UFOs are real." Roper asks whether "UFOs [are] . . . from somewhere else in the universe." Both questions, and essentially all others, use the word "UFO." Given this, the Roper wording is most analogous to the Scripps Howard question, and Roper has found support ranging from 25–30% in its surveys. That is statistically consistent with the current findings.

We should linger for a moment on these results. Fully one-third of our fellow Americans believe it is somewhat likely or likely that ETI has visited Earth. That is an astounding fact, one which drives the scientific, political, and media elite bonkers, in this country and others. Of course, those of us interested in UFOs aren't astonished: Why *shouldn't* belief be this high, given the likelihood that ETI exists and the massive evidence supplied by UFO reports? Just

remember that if you believe, as do many *IUR* readers, that ETI is the cause of some UFO reports, your belief is shared by plenty of the people you meet and know, even if you've never discussed it.

Next we'll see how the same demographic variables we studied above are related to belief in ETI visits.

Gender. In a different pattern than belief in ETI, there is no significant difference in belief in ETI visits between males and females. I didn't anticipate this (and we'll learn below that more males than females see UFOs), so I don't have a ready explanation.

Age. The pattern here is identical to that for belief in ETI. Except for very young adults, belief is highest among the 55–64 age group (48.1%) and lowest among the 25–34 age group (21.8%). We can surmise that the same reasons apply.

Region. There is no difference in belief by region of the country, which was not true for belief in ETI.

Residential location. Continuing the refrain, there is no difference in belief in ETI visits by residential location. Those who live in the suburbs do have a higher level of belief, but only by a few percentage points.

Education. Here there is a relationship, but it is one that reverses the common finding that the most educated have a higher level of belief in UFOs. The greatest belief in ETI visits is among those with a high school education or less (45.7%), with all those having more education about 10 percentage points lower (see Figure 3). No other control variable reduces the pattern, so this is a bit of an anomaly.

Political position. The strongest relationship of ETI visits with any variable is with political position, just as it was with ETI existence, and the pattern is the same. Conservatives have a lower level of belief in ETI visits and liberals have a much higher level of belief (see Figure 4).

Previously I added residential location as a control and found an interaction. There is an interaction here as well, and residential location reduces the differences by political position. There is no difference in belief among those who

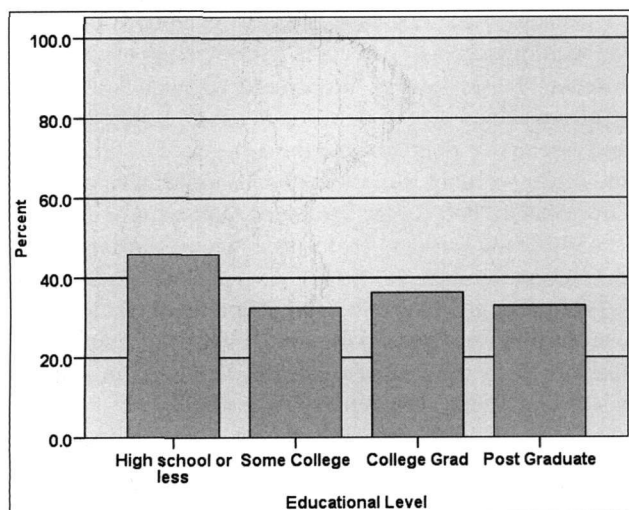


Fig. 3. Belief in ETI visits by education level

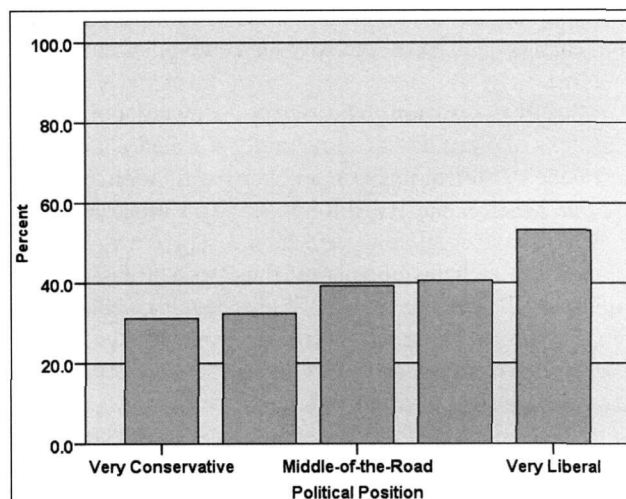


Fig. 4. Belief in ETI visits by political position

live in large cities or rural areas. Conservatives in small cities and suburbs have a lower level of belief than liberals.

Religious affiliation. Also consistent with their lower belief in ETI's existence, Protestants have a lower belief in ETI visits (25.3%) than do those of other religions or those with no religion. Intriguingly, adding born again as a control variable *does not* remove this difference for those Protestants who were not born again.

This same relationship has been found in other surveys, such as a Baylor University–sponsored survey done in 2008. Traditional Christians were less likely to believe in bigfoot, astrology, and UFOs, among other paranormal topics. Many possible reasons have been suggested. One possibility is that the interpretation of the UFO phenomenon within many Protestant denominations is that UFO reports are real, but they are not extraterrestrial in origin. Instead, what witnesses see is, literally, the Devil and his minions, here to do mischief. Thus, these people would respond that it is unlikely that ETI has visited Earth because UFO reports are not caused by ETI.

HAD A UFO SIGHTING

The third key question on the Scripps Howard survey asked, “Have you, personally, ever seen a mysterious object in the sky that might have been a visitor from another world?” This is a narrower version of the standard “Have you seen a UFO?” question because it limits the UFO's source to extraterrestrials, not weird unexplained natural phenomena. Consequently, we might expect that the proportion answering yes will be somewhat lower than other surveys. Typically, about 8–10% of adults will say they have seen a UFO. On the Scripps Howard survey 7.6% say they have had such a UFO sighting, which is slightly lower, consistent with my conjecture.

Which groups have had more, or fewer, sightings? Before we begin, we can make a prediction. Generally, demographic characteristics should be less related to having a UFO sighting than to beliefs about UFOs. When those characteristics

are important, they should commonly have an effect because they change one's opportunity to have a sighting.

Gender. Every past study shows that males have more sightings than females, and we find the same here. About 9.5% of the males had a sighting versus 5.6% of the females. Consistent with the prediction above, this difference has been attributed to males being out later at night and in isolated areas and thus having more opportunities to see a UFO.

Age. Somewhat oddly, the sighting rate follows the pattern of ETI belief. That is, the older you are, the more likely you are to report a sighting (13.4% of those 55–64 years old). But the rate then drops a bit to 10.3% among those 65 and above, but that is still much higher than for younger people. The simplest explanation is also consistent with the prediction: The primary reason that older people report more sightings is that they have lived longer and had more exposure time, as epidemiologists would say. And all things being equal, living longer should lead to more chances to see a UFO (although I've managed not to see one myself despite my age).

Region. UFOs have been seen all over the United States, but it appears that the West is the place to be. Those in the West region report a much higher frequency of sightings (15.1%) than any other region (the next closest is the South at 6.4%). Is it the clear skies, the wide open spaces, or something else?

Residential location. There are differences by residential location. Figure 5 shows that respondents from the suburbs and rural areas had more sightings than those in cities. People who live in the suburbs and rural areas have more open space and fewer intrusive lights to block any UFOs that might appear. And, on the average, UFO sightings are more frequent away from cities, taking into account population size.

Education. Those with less education had a higher rate of UFO sightings by a factor of about 2 (see Figure 6). Recall from the previous section that these same groups had a higher level of belief that ETI had visited Earth. Even so, it isn't clear that the same pattern with education should hold for both,

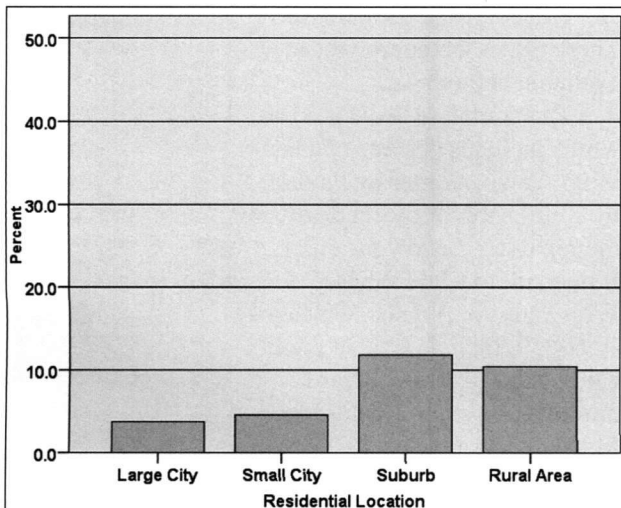


Fig. 5. Had a UFO sighting by residential location

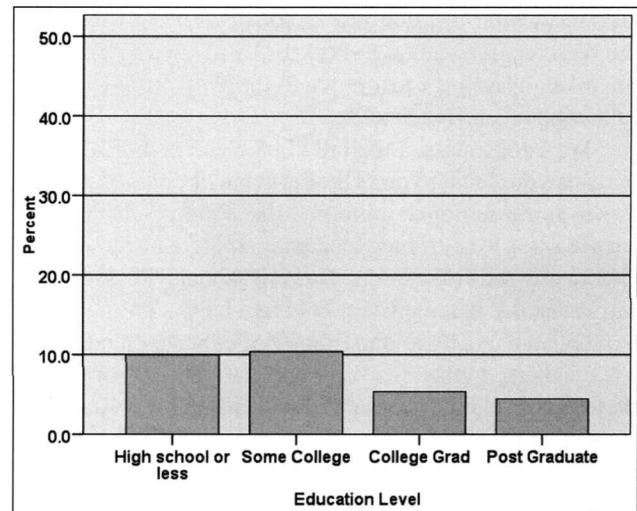


Fig. 6. Had a UFO sighting by education level

and this one is a bit of a puzzle. It doesn't obviously follow from differences in chances to see UFOs (adding gender as a control variable doesn't change the relationship).

Political position. Political position shouldn't be related strongly to having a UFO sighting, and indeed it isn't. The highest rate, although not statistically distinct, is for those middle-of-the-road at 9.9%.

Religious affiliation. There should also be no relationship for religious affiliation, and there is not. Christians may be more "immune" to believing that UFOs may be extraterrestrial spaceships, but that doesn't prevent them from having UFO sightings like other people. And being born again is also not related to having a sighting, although the relationship is in the right direction (those born again have a lower percentage).

IDEAL TYPES

To finish our scrutiny of the survey results, we can have a bit of fun and construct a profile of those individuals who have the highest belief in ETI, the highest belief that ETI has visited Earth, and those with more UFO sightings.

Belief in ETI. Males who are Baby Boomers and profess to be liberals are very likely (88.6%) to believe in the existence of ETI. Belief is almost as high (85.7%) for males who live in the West and are liberal (the numbers are too small to put all four characteristics in one table).

Belief ETI has visited Earth. One group with high levels of belief is liberals with a high school or less education (59.3%). And although there was no difference by region itself, Baby Boomers who live in the West have higher levels of belief (53.3%). In general, differences between demographic groups are less pronounced on this question than on the existence of ETI.

UFO sighting. Go West, young man! Although the number of cases is small (26), males who live in suburbs in the West have an extraordinarily high sighting rate of 53.8%, about seven times greater than the norm. Even if we don't

take residential location into account, 25.5% of males in the West report a sighting. (Perhaps I still have a chance for my own sighting if I just move to the West from Chicago, following Allen Hynek's lead.)

We've just passed the fall 2008 election as I write, so perhaps you've had your fill of articles like this that break down some national opinion—the support for various candidates—by all types of demographic and ideological characteristics. This exercise for belief about ETIs and UFOs can be useful. Knowing that having a UFO sighting seems to be related mostly to opportunity of exposure lends some basic validity to the idea that people are seeing something they can't explain. It doesn't tell us what is seen. And if we were more prepared, knowing who believes in UFOs would provide us opportunities to reach out to people more likely to support the efforts of organized ufology.

I will remain content that, whether direct supporters or not, a large proportion of the population is clearly in sympathy with our efforts to study the UFO phenomenon.

NOTES

1. For what it's worth, the survey included a question about who the respondent would vote for in a McCain vs. Obama race. Dropping those who were undecided or gave an irrelevant response, the results were Obama 53.5% and McCain 46.5%, almost exactly the election result over five months later.

2. Unlike overnight telephone polls done by major news organizations, the Scripps Howard poll was completed over a two-week period. This allowed for numerous callbacks to a telephone number before giving up and substituting another number. This approach is the best method to ensure a more

representative sample for this type of data collection.

3. When differences are presented between groups, I have done statistical tests using the conventional 95% significance level.

4. With even a dozen or so variables, there are innumerable different three-way tables that can be constructed. It's hard to tell on which ones to focus, which is why academics develop theories and make predictions/hypotheses before doing data analysis. This allows them to isolate the effects that they want to study and not engage in data dredging. Our analysis here is suggestive and in the spirit of cautious data exploration.

5. One's faith in the logical reasoning of American adults is bolstered by the fact that only 2.8% of those who thought that ETI is unlikely to exist also believed it to be likely that ETI has visited Earth. ♦

STRANGE DAYS—continued from page 10

for intelligence leaks through telepathy. In 1957, Puharich published an article entitled "Can Telepathy Penetrate the Iron Curtain?" in *Tomorrow* magazine. One wonders whether that was part of some "shake up the Soviets" mind game. Whatever the motivation, it seems that the race to avoid the "Trance Control Medium Gap" was on. It ended in the now well-publicized remote viewing experiments at Stanford Research Institute by Hal Puthoff and Russell Targ, under the secret overseership of the CIA (I think), or the DIA (I think), or somebody (I think). Let's see: Stanford Research Institute and the Hoover Institution, Stanford University . . . I wonder if . . . ? Hal, who is a friend, once told me: "Oh, yes, Steve [Possony] used to come over once in a while and ask how we were doing. Never knew that he was interested in UFOs or I'd have asked him."

Bet he wouldn't have told you, Hal.

Oh yeah, almost forgot. Puharich didn't just retire. He went on to be the parapsychological godfather of the spoon-bending Uri Geller (tested at SRI by Hal, by the way). Where did Geller get his powers? Beamed into his head, by UFOs. ♦

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